



Art and Architecture of India – Ashoka Pillars (Mauryan Period)

The **Ashoka Pillars** are one of the most remarkable achievements of **Mauryan art and architecture** (3rd century BCE) under Emperor Ashoka. They reflect the **political, religious, and artistic sophistication** of the Mauryan Empire.



Historical Background

- Emperor Ashoka ruled the Mauryan Empire after the Kalinga War (261 BCE).
 - Converted to **Buddhism** and promoted **Dhamma (moral law, non-violence, tolerance)**.
 - Erected **pillars and edicts** across India to spread Buddhist teachings.
 - Around **30–40 pillars** still survive at various locations.
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Features of Ashoka Pillars

1. **Material:** Polished **sandstone** (often from Chunar near Varanasi).
 2. **Height:** Varies from **12 to 15 meters**, including the capital.
 3. **Shape:** Monolithic (single stone), smooth cylindrical shaft.
 4. **Polish:** Highly polished, called “**Mauryan polish**”; metallic luster without coating.
 5. **Inscriptions:**
 - Written in **Brahmi script**
 - Carved with **edicts of Ashoka** promoting moral and religious values
 6. **Location:** Spread across India, including Sarnath, Vaishali, Delhi, Lauriya Nandangarh, and Rampurva.
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Components of an Ashoka Pillar



1 Shaft

- Smooth, polished stone.
- Often **cylindrical**, sometimes slightly tapering at the top.
- Carved with **edicts** on the surface.



2 Capital

- Ornamental top piece, often animal figures.
- Famous capitals include:
 - **Lion Capital of Sarnath** (National Emblem of India)
 - **Bull, Elephant, Horse, or Lion capitals**
- Carved with **lotus or bell-shaped abacus** supporting animal sculptures.

3 Abacus

- Circular platform beneath animal sculptures.
- Decorated with **geometrical or floral patterns**.
- Sometimes depicts **mythical animals (yalis)** or **wheel (chakra)** motifs.

◆ Famous Ashoka Pillars

Location	Capital	Notes
Sarnath (Uttar Pradesh)	Lion	Adopted as National Emblem of India ; four lions back-to-back; wheel (Ashoka Chakra) below
Rampurva (Bihar)	Bull	Represents strength and fertility
Lauriya Nandangarh (Bihar)	Lion	Edicts inscribed; finely polished
Sanchi (Madhya Pradesh)	Elephant	Symbolizes Buddha's birth and royal authority
Delhi-Topra	Lion	Originally in Topra, Haryana; moved to Delhi

◆ Artistic Features

1. **Realism and naturalism**
 - Animals are **life-like**, finely carved.
 - Expression and musculature detailed.
2. **Polished finish**
 - "Mauryan polish" gives mirror-like surface.
 - Unique for its time in world art.
3. **Symbolism**
 - Lion → Power, authority, and Dharma
 - Bull → Strength, fertility, and prosperity
 - Chakra → Wheel of Dharma (moral law)
 - Lotus → Purity and spiritual growth
4. **Inscriptions (Edicts)**
 - Written in **Brahmi script**
 - Convey **moral, social, and administrative messages**
 - Promote non-violence, tolerance, respect for life, and Buddhism

◆ Purpose of Ashoka Pillars

1. Spread **Buddhist teachings** and ethical principles.
 2. Serve as **symbols of imperial authority**.
 3. Educate people on **Dhamma (righteousness)**.
 4. Promote **unity and governance** across Mauryan Empire.
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◆ Influence on Later Art

- Inspired **Gupta and post-Gupta sculpture**.
 - Use of **animal capitals and polished stone** influenced Indian temple art.
 - Ashoka Chakra in **Indian National Flag** originates from Sarnath Lion Capital.
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◆ Summary of Characteristics

Feature	Details
Material	Polished sandstone
Height	12–15 meters
Capitals	Lion, bull, elephant, horse
Decoration	Lotus abacus, chakra, floral motifs
Script	Brahmi
Purpose	Spread Buddhism, imperial propaganda, moral teaching
Artistic Style	Realistic, symbolic, highly polished

★ Conclusion

The **Ashoka Pillars** are a unique blend of **art, religion, and political symbolism**. They reflect the **Mauryan Empire's sophistication**, Emperor Ashoka's moral vision, and the high technical skill of ancient Indian sculptors. Their **symbolism and elegance** continue to inspire Indian art and national identity today.



Art and Architecture of India – Sanchi Stupa (Mauryan–Sunga Period)

The **Sanchi Stupa** is one of the **most famous Buddhist monuments in India**. It is a masterpiece of **ancient Indian architecture and art**, representing the **Buddhist religious and cultural heritage** of the 3rd century BCE onwards.

- **Location:** Sanchi, Madhya Pradesh
 - **Constructed:** Originally by Ashoka in 3rd century BCE
 - **Period:** Mauryan–Sunga era with later expansions
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Historical Background

- Built under **Emperor Ashoka** after his conversion to **Buddhism** post-Kalinga War.
 - Intended to **house relics of the Buddha**.
 - Expanded and decorated by later rulers of the **Sunga dynasty** (2nd century BCE).
 - Considered a **pilgrimage site** and an important center for Buddhist teachings.
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Architectural Features of Sanchi Stupa

The Sanchi Stupa is a **hemispherical mound (Anda)** with various architectural components:

1

Anda (Dome)

- Semi-spherical brick or stone structure.
 - Symbolizes **Buddha's burial mound (relics inside)**.
 - Houses **Buddha's relics** in a **relic chamber** at the center.
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2

Harmika

- Small square railing at the top of the dome.
 - Represents the **celestial abode** or sacred enclosure.
 - Surmounted by the **Chhatra (umbrella)**, symbolizing high rank and honor.
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3 Chhatra (Umbrella)

- Triple-tiered umbrella structure above the harmika.
 - Symbolizes **sovereignty and protection**.
 - Represents **Buddha's high spiritual status**.
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4 Medhi (Circular Terrace)

- Wide circular walkway around the dome.
 - Pilgrims perform **pradakshina (circumambulation)** on this path.
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5 Toranas (Gateways)

- Four elaborately carved gateways facing **north, south, east, west**.
- Constructed by Sungas in 1st century BCE.
- Made of **sandstone**.
- Richly decorated with **scenes from Buddha's life, Jataka tales, and symbols** (lotus, wheel, elephants, lions).

◆ Artistic Features of Toranas

- Narrative relief sculptures: Stories of Buddha's previous lives (Jataka tales).
 - Symbolic motifs: Dharma chakra (wheel of law), lotus, vajra.
 - Figures of humans, animals, and mythological beings.
 - High craftsmanship, realistic forms, and expressive carvings.
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6 Vedika (Stone railing)

- Stone railing encircles the stupa.
 - Provides **sacred boundary** for worshipers.
 - Carved with **lotus motifs, elephants, and geometric designs**.
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◆ Symbolism of the Stupa

Component	Symbolism
Dome (Anda)	Universe, Buddha's body, cosmic mound
Harmika	Celestial abode

Component	Symbolism
Chhatra	Sovereignty, spiritual protection
Toranas	Gateway to enlightenment, storytelling
Medhi	Path of devotion and pilgrimage
Vedika	Sacred boundary, protection

Artistic and Cultural Importance

1. **Earliest stone architecture in India**
 2. **Fusion of religion and art** – Sculptures narrate Buddhist stories visually.
 3. **Influence on later stupas** like Sarnath, Bharhut, and Amaravati.
 4. **Pilgrimage site** – Attracts devotees and scholars alike.
 5. **UNESCO World Heritage Site** – Preserves Mauryan and Sunga-era art.
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Style and Technique

- **Stone carving:** Deep reliefs with fine details.
 - **Symbolic representation:** Buddha rarely shown directly; use of **symbols like footprints, lotus, and wheel.**
 - **Narrative art:** Stories depicted in panels for educational and devotional purposes.
 - **Polished stone work:** Inspired by Mauryan polish technique.
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Importance of Sanchi Stupa

1. First monumental **Buddhist architecture** in India.
 2. Preserves **Mauryan and Sunga art and sculpture.**
 3. Illustrates the **transition from aniconic (symbolic) to iconic representation** of Buddha.
 4. Shows the **integration of religion, art, and architecture.**
 5. Served as a **model for later Buddhist stupas** across Asia.
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Conclusion

The **Sanchi Stupa** is a **symbol of India's ancient Buddhist heritage**, combining **architecture, sculpture, and symbolism.** Its **dome, toranas, chhatra, and carvings** represent religious devotion, artistic mastery, and cultural sophistication. It remains a **key site**

for understanding Mauryan and Sunga art and a milestone in world architectural history.



Art and Architecture of India – Ajanta and Ellora Caves

The **Ajanta and Ellora caves** are the most famous examples of **rock-cut architecture** in India, reflecting the **religious, artistic, and cultural excellence** of ancient and medieval India. They were primarily Buddhist, Jain, and Hindu monastic complexes.



Ajanta Caves



Location

- Near **Aurangabad, Maharashtra**
- Carved into a horseshoe-shaped cliff in the **Waghora river valley**



Historical Background

- Constructed in **two phases**:
 1. **2nd century BCE – 1st century CE** (Hinayana phase – early Buddhist)
 2. **5th–6th century CE** (Mahayana phase – Gupta period)
 - Patronized by **Vakataka rulers**, especially Emperor Harishena.
 - Functioned as **Buddhist monasteries and worship halls**.
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Features

1. **Rock-Cut Monasteries (Viharas)**
 - Residential complexes for monks.
 - Contain cells, meditation halls, and assembly halls.
 - Example: **Cave 1, Cave 2**.
2. **Chaitya Halls**
 - Prayer halls for congregational worship.
 - Feature **stupa at the end** of hall.
 - Example: **Cave 26** – largest chaitya, 16 pillars, carved wooden-like ceiling in stone.
3. **Sculpture and Carvings**
 - Elaborate sculptures of **Buddha and Bodhisattvas**.
 - Depictions of **Jataka tales** (stories of Buddha's previous lives).
4. **Fresco Paintings**
 - Wall paintings in natural mineral pigments.
 - Themes: Buddha's life, royal figures, court scenes, everyday life.

- Example: **The Bodhisattva Padmapani in Cave 1.**
 - Style: graceful, expressive, naturalistic forms with flowing lines.
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◆ Importance of Ajanta Caves

- Showcase **ancient Indian painting and mural art.**
 - Illustrate **Buddhist religious life and philosophy.**
 - Evidence of **Gupta-period art excellence.**
 - UNESCO World Heritage Site.
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◆ 2 Ellora Caves

📍 Location

- Near **Aurangabad, Maharashtra**
- Rock-cut caves along **Dakini river valley**

🏛️ Historical Background

- Constructed between **6th and 10th centuries CE.**
 - Represent **Hinduism, Buddhism, and Jainism** (multi-religious complex).
 - Example of **religious tolerance in Indian art.**
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◆ Features

1. **Number of Caves**
 - **34 caves** in total:
 - **Buddhist (caves 1–12)** – monasteries, chaityas
 - **Hindu (caves 13–29)** – temples, rock-cut shrines
 - **Jain (caves 30–34)** – intricate carvings
2. **Rock-Cut Temples**
 - Caves are excavated from **solid basalt cliffs.**
 - Free-standing structural features carved **entirely out of rock.**
3. **Kailasa Temple (Cave 16)**
 - Dedicated to **Lord Shiva**
 - Largest monolithic rock excavation in the world
 - Multi-storied, complete with **temples, courtyards, and sculptural panels**
 - Sculptures of **Shiva, Parvati, Nandi, and scenes from epics (Ramayana, Mahabharata)**
4. **Sculpture and Carvings**
 - Detailed **stone sculptures of gods, goddesses, dancers, musicians**

- High reliefs, narrative panels
 - Represent **classical Indian iconography**
 - 5. **Buddhist Caves**
 - Viharas (monasteries) and Chaityas (prayer halls)
 - Early Buddhist style: simple, functional
 - Later Mahayana style: elaborate sculptures
 - 6. **Jain Caves**
 - Very intricate carvings
 - Highly ornate pillars and ceilings
 - Example: Cave 32 – Parsvanatha temple with detailed ceilings
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◆ Importance of Ellora Caves

- Demonstrates **multi-religious art and coexistence**.
 - Example of **rock-cut architectural mastery**.
 - Kailasa Temple is a **unique monolithic wonder**.
 - Showcases **advancements in sculpture, iconography, and engineering**.
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◆ Comparison of Ajanta and Ellora

Feature	Ajanta	Ellora
Period	2nd BCE – 6th CE	6th – 10th CE
Religion	Buddhist	Buddhist, Hindu, Jain
Type	Monasteries and Chaityas	Monasteries, Temples, Shrines
Art	Murals, frescoes, sculptures	Rock-cut sculptures, Kailasa temple
Famous	Bodhisattva Padmapani (Cave 1)	Kailasa Temple (Cave 16)
Focus	Painting and storytelling	Architecture and monumental sculpture
Patronage	Vakataka dynasty	Rashtrakuta dynasty (Hindu), others

★ Conclusion

- **Ajanta Caves** – center of **Buddhist religious art and painting**, reflecting spiritual life and narrative art.
 - **Ellora Caves** – masterful example of **rock-cut architecture, sculpture, and religious tolerance**, with the **Kailasa Temple** as a world wonder.
 - Together, they highlight India's **technological, artistic, and religious brilliance** during ancient and medieval periods.
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Art and Architecture of India – Konark Sun Temple

The **Konark Sun Temple** is one of the most remarkable examples of **medieval Indian temple architecture**, known for its **monumental scale, intricate carvings, and symbolic design**. It is dedicated to the **Sun God (Surya)** and reflects the **artistic and engineering brilliance of the Eastern Ganga dynasty**.

- **Location:** Konark, Odisha
 - **Built:** 13th century CE (~1250 CE)
 - **Patron:** King Narasimhadeva I
 - **Style:** Kalinga (Odishan) architecture
 - **UNESCO World Heritage Site:** 1984
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Historical Background

- Constructed during the reign of **Narasimhadeva I** (Eastern Ganga dynasty).
 - Built to honor the **Sun God**, who rides across the sky in his chariot.
 - Designed as a **giant chariot of Surya**, with wheels and horses carved in stone.
 - Believed to have been a center for **pilgrimage and Sun worship**.
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Architectural Features

The Konark Sun Temple is a **chariot-shaped temple** with symbolic and functional elements:

1

Chariot Form

- Temple designed as **Sun God's chariot**.
 - **12 pairs of stone wheels** with intricate carvings.
 - **7 horses** pulling the chariot, representing **days of the week**.
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2

Vimana (Sanctum Tower)

- Main sanctum once housed the **idol of Surya**, now destroyed.
- Tower (Vimana) originally about **200 feet high**.
- Represents the **divine abode of the Sun God**.

3 Jagamohana (Assembly Hall)

- Also called **Nata Mandir** or audience hall.
- Rectangular hall for devotees.
- Contains elaborate **sculptural panels and pillars**.

4 Sculptural Ornamentation

- Temple walls covered with **over 1,000 detailed sculptures**.
- Depict **deities, dancers, musicians, animals, and erotic scenes**.
- Carvings also show **daily life, festivals, and hunting scenes**.
- **Erotic sculptures** reflect the **Tantric tradition** and spiritual symbolism.

5 Stone Wheels

- **24 wheels**, each 10 feet in diameter.
- Detailed **spokes and rim carvings**.
- Each wheel serves as a **sundial**, showing **time using shadow**.

6 Horses

- **Seven horses** carved in stone, symbolize **seven days of the week**.
- Positioned as if **pulling the chariot** of Surya across the sky.

7 Alignment

- Temple **faces the east**, so the first rays of the sun fall on the deity.
- Represents **cosmic symbolism of the Sun God's journey**.

Artistic Features

1. **Intricate Carvings**
 - Sculptures show **mythological scenes, celestial beings, and ordinary life**.

- Erotic art inspired by **Tantric and Vaishnavite traditions**.
 - 2. **Engineering Marvel**
 - Constructed entirely from **chlorite, laterite, and sandstone** without mortar.
 - Carvings are both **decorative and structural**.
 - 3. **Symbolism**
 - Wheels = **time and motion**
 - Horses = **energy and speed of the Sun**
 - Temple structure = **cosmic representation**
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Cultural and Religious Importance

- Major center of **Sun worship in Odisha**.
 - Reflects **medieval Odishan temple architecture (Kalinga style)**.
 - Inspired later **temples in Eastern India**.
 - Recognized as a **UNESCO World Heritage Site** for its **artistic, architectural, and cultural value**.
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Kalinga Architectural Features

Feature	Konark Temple Details
Style	Kalinga (Odishan)
Sanctum (Vimana)	Chariot-shaped, East-facing
Assembly Hall	Jagamohana / Nata Mandir
Wheels	24, function as sundials
Horses	7, represent days of the week
Sculptures	Gods, humans, animals, dancers, erotic art
Material	Chlorite, laterite, sandstone
Symbolism	Sun's chariot, cosmic order, motion of time

Conclusion

The **Konark Sun Temple** is a **symbol of medieval Indian art, architecture, and devotion**. Its **chariot form, wheels, horses, and intricate sculptures** reflect the **scientific, religious, and artistic brilliance** of the Eastern Ganga dynasty.

It stands not only as a **temple for Sun worship** but also as a **masterpiece of Indian rock-cut and stone architecture**, combining **engineering, astronomy, and art** in perfect harmony.



Art and Architecture of India – Khajuraho Temples and Medieval Monuments

India's **medieval art and architecture** (8th–12th centuries CE) witnessed remarkable developments, especially in **temple architecture**, characterized by **intricate carvings, monumental structures, and symbolic designs**. Among these, the **Khajuraho temples** are the most famous, along with various **forts, mosques, and other monuments** from the medieval period.



Khajuraho Temples



Location

- Khajuraho, Madhya Pradesh
- Built by the **Chandela dynasty** between **950–1050 CE**



Historical Background

- Chandela kings ruled central India (Bundelkhand region).
 - Temples were primarily **Shaivite, Vaishnavite, and Jain**.
 - Purpose: Religious devotion, royal prestige, and artistic expression.
 - Famous for **erotic sculptures and intricate carvings**, reflecting Tantric philosophy.
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Architectural Features



Temple Layout

- Temples follow **Nagara style (North Indian architecture)**:
 - **Garbhagriha (sanctum sanctorum)** – houses the main deity
 - **Mandapa (assembly hall)** – for devotees
 - **Shikhara (tower)** – rises above the sanctum
 - **Jagati (platform)** – raised plinth for circumambulation



Material

- Constructed using **sandstone** (locally available).
- Stones were **polished and finely carved**.

3 Sculptural Ornamentation

- Temples decorated with **over 20,000 sculptures**:
 - Gods and goddesses
 - Apsaras (celestial dancers)
 - Musicians and warriors
 - Daily life scenes
 - Erotic sculptures (Kama Sutra inspired)

4 Notable Temples

Temple	Deity	Special Features
Kandariya Mahadev	Shiva	Tallest (31 m), exquisite carvings, elaborate shikhara
Lakshmana	Vishnu	Intricate carvings, elevated platform
Chaturbhuja	Vishnu	Elegant proportions, minimal erotic sculpture
Jain Temples	Jain Tirthankaras	Simpler ornamentation, serene figures

◆ Artistic Features

1. **Erotic sculptures**
 - Symbolize **Tantric philosophy**: unity of human and divine, cosmic energy.
 2. **High relief sculptures**
 - Figures are lifelike, dynamic, and expressive.
 3. **Narrative panels**
 - Depict stories from **Ramayana, Mahabharata, Puranas**.
 4. **Shikhara and Mandapa**
 - Towers decorated with miniature shikharas, giving a **mountain-like appearance**.
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◆ Cultural Importance

- Represents the **zenith of Chandela art**.
 - Shows **integration of religion, art, and architecture**.
 - UNESCO World Heritage Site (1986).
 - Demonstrates **medieval Indian craftsmanship and spiritual symbolism**.
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◆ 2 Various Medieval Monuments in India

India's **medieval architecture (8th–18th centuries CE)** includes **Hindu, Jain, Islamic, and Sikh monuments**, reflecting **regional styles, materials, and religious influences**.

◆ 2A. Hindu and Jain Temples

Monument	Location	Period	Features
Sun Temple	Konark, Odisha	13th c.	Chariot-shaped, wheels, horses, intricate carvings
Lingaraja Temple	Bhubaneswar, Odisha	11th c.	Nagara style, massive shikhara, stone carvings
Hoysaleswara Temple	Halebidu, Karnataka	12th c.	Soapstone, Hoysala style, erotic and mythological carvings
Dilwara Temples	Mount Abu, Rajasthan	11th–13th c.	Jain temples, marble, intricate lattice work
Brihadeeswarar Temple	Thanjavur, Tamil Nadu	11th c.	Chola dynasty, massive granite shikhara, bronze sculptures

◆ 2B. Islamic Architecture

Monument	Location	Period	Features
Qutb Minar	Delhi	1193 CE	Tall minaret, Indo-Islamic style, red sandstone
Alai Darwaza	Delhi	1311 CE	Arched gateway, Islamic geometric patterns
Gol Gumbaz	Bijapur, Karnataka	1656 CE	Mausoleum, large dome, whispering gallery
Jama Masjid	Delhi	1650 CE	Large congregational mosque, Mughal architecture
Charminar	Hyderabad	1591 CE	Four minarets, Indo-Islamic style, landmark structure

◆ 2C. Forts and Palaces

Monument	Location	Period	Features
Red Fort	Delhi	1639 CE	Mughal architecture, sandstone, marble
Agra Fort	Agra	16th c.	Massive walls, Mughal decorative style
Gwalior Fort	Madhya Pradesh	Medieval	Hilltop fort, temples, palaces
Chittorgarh Fort	Rajasthan	7th–16th c.	Rajput architecture, palaces, temples

◆ Features of Medieval Indian Monuments

1. **Material:** Stone, sandstone, granite, marble.
 2. **Style:**
 - North India – **Nagara (temples), Indo-Islamic (mosques/forts)**
 - South India – **Dravidian style (temples with vimanas)**
 - Central India – **Orissan and Chandela styles**
 3. **Decorations:**
 - Carvings of gods, animals, celestial beings, floral motifs.
 - Frescoes and murals (in some temples).
 4. **Symbolism:**
 - Temples: cosmic order, divine abode
 - Forts: military strength, royal power
 - Islamic monuments: symmetry, calligraphy, domes, arches
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Conclusion

- **Khajuraho temples** represent the **height of Chandela artistry**, combining **religious devotion, erotic symbolism, and sculptural mastery**.
 - **Medieval Indian monuments** show **diverse styles** – Hindu, Jain, Islamic – reflecting **regional variations, religious tolerance, and technological advancement**.
 - Together, they highlight India's **rich cultural, artistic, and architectural heritage** during the medieval period.
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